(second century CE) told one copyist, 'You are doing Heaven's work, and if you delete one letter or add one letter – you destroy the entire world.'[29] In truth, copying errors crept in without destroying the entire world, and no two ancient Bibles were identical.[30]

A second and much bigger problem concerned interpretation. Even when people agree on the sanctity of a book and on its exact wording, they can still interpret the same words in different ways. The Bible says that you should not work on the Sabbath. But it doesn't clarify what counts as 'work'. Is it okay to water your field on the Sabbath? What about watering your flowerpot or herd of goats? Is it okay to read a book on the Sabbath? How about writing a book? How about tearing a piece of paper? The rabbis ruled that reading a book isn't work, but tearing paper *is* work, which is why nowadays Orthodox Jews prepare a stack of already ripped toilet paper to use on the Sabbath.

The holy book also says that you should not cook a young goat in its mother's milk (Exodus 23:19). Some people interpreted this quite literally: if you slaughter a young goat, don't cook it in the milk of its own mother. But it's fine to cook it in the milk of an unrelated goat, or in the milk of a cow. Other people interpreted this prohibition much more broadly to mean that meat and dairy products should never be mixed, so you are not allowed to have a milkshake after fried chicken. As unlikely as this may sound, most rabbis ruled that the second interpretation is the correct one, even though chickens don't lactate.

More problems resulted from the fact that even if the technology of the book succeeded in limiting changes to the holy words, the world beyond the book continued to spin, and it was unclear how to relate old rules to new situations. Most biblical texts focused on the lives of Jewish shepherds and farmers in the hill country of Palestine and in the sacred city of Jerusalem. But by the second century CE, most Jews lived elsewhere. A particularly large Jewish community grew in the port of Alexandria, one of the richest metropolises of the Roman Empire. A Jewish shipping magnate living in Alexandria would have found that many of the biblical laws were irrelevant to his life while many of his pressing questions had no clear answers in the holy text. He couldn't obey the commandments about worshipping in the Jerusalem temple, because not only did he not live near Jerusalem, but the temple didn't even exist anymore. In contrast, when he contemplated whether it was kosher for him to sail his Rome-bound grain ships on the